

Facilitator Kit • Parent Night Presentation Script (30 Minutes)

Trust your hackles. Pause • Check • Tell.

Trust your hackles. Pause • Check • Tell.

FIELD COPY



PLATE I. The six strands, hand-inked, in the order the lessons take them.

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OCTOBER 2026

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Hackles Facilitator Kit, Document 8 of 10. A warm, practical, no-fear-tactics 30-minute presentation for families, with a word-for-word script, two do-together activities, and answers to the questions parents actually ask. For the longer 75-minute Family Night, see the Hackles Day Kit, Section 8.

[Logo: Hackles]

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No student accounts, no student data collected, ever.

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01 The goal and the five rules of tone

THE GOAL

WHEN FAMILIES LEAVE, THEY should feel **welcome, informed and equipped**, and they should be able to do three things at home this week:

1. Say "Thank you for telling me. This is not your fault. You are not in trouble."
2. Pick a **Family Code Word** (or at least decide to).
3. Start one conversation with their child about "Hackles up? Pause. Check. Tell."

FIVE RULES OF TONE

1. **Warm, hopeful, practical.** Open with welcome. Danger can wait.
2. **No fear tactics.** No alarming statistics at the start. No stories about real children. No pictures of hooded figures. If you quote any number at all, use the current figure from a primary source (such as NCMEC, the FBI, Pew or Common Sense) and mark it as approximate.
3. **Recognition and response only.** Say what to notice and what to do. Don't describe the methods of people who harm children.
4. **No blame.** Not of parents, not of children, not of "the kids today."
5. **Families are partners.** "You know your child best."

Hold this line even if the room asks for more fear. Someone may say "Tell us the scary stuff!" The answer: "Fear isn't what protects children. A calm adult, a clear routine, and a child who knows they can tell: that's what protects them. That's what we'll practice tonight."

02 Who presents, and the team

ROLE	WHO	WHAT THEY DO
Host	Principal or assistant principal	Welcomes, introduces the team, thanks families, closes
Teacher voice	A teacher or librarian who has taught a Hackles lesson	Shows what the lessons look like (a 2-minute live demo)
Counselor	School counselor	Leads "When your child tells you something hard," is available for private conversations
Greeters and helpers	Teachers, aides, PTA volunteers	Sign-in, interpreters, table help, childcare
Student guests (optional)	Older students, with family permission	Short skit: Hackles up? Pause. Check. Tell. (See the Hackles Day Kit.)

IF YOU'RE AT A small school, one person can host and teach, but the counselor should still attend or be on call. **Do not run this night without the counselor available.** A parent may need a private conversation, and you won't be the right person to have it.

03 Before the night: preparation checklist

- ☐ Date, time, place and childcare booked. Interpreters booked. [VERIFY language access policy]
- ☐ Invitation sent 2 to 3 weeks before (sample in Section 12), in families' home languages.
- ☐ Counselor confirmed, and a quiet room for private conversations identified.
- ☐ Materials printed (Section 10).
- ☐ Slides prepared (Section 9), with large type.
- ☐ Wall of student work or a "What kids will learn" display set up.
- ☐ The Help Map (H7) filled in so you can answer "who do I call?"
- ☐ A calm, practiced script. Rehearse out loud once.
- ☐ Policies checked: Can families preview materials? What is our opt-out process for sensitive lessons? [VERIFY]
- ☐ Photo policy decided. Do not photograph families without permission. [VERIFY]
- ☐ Refreshments with allergy labels (optional). [VERIFY food rules]

04 Room, materials and access

- **Room:** chairs in a half-circle or at tables of 4 to 6. A table at the back for sign-in and handouts. A "What kids will learn" display (the Hackles routine poster, a sample lesson, sample cards).
- **Accessibility:** step-free entry, large-print copies, a hearing loop or captions if possible, a seat for anyone who cannot stand, a quiet space.
- **Interpreters and translated handouts** at the sign-in table.
- **Childcare:** a separate room supervised per school policy. [VERIFY]
- **Technology:** a screen, but nothing depends on it. No family devices needed. No sign-in to any account.
- **Privacy:** sign-in sheet with first names or initials only if your policy requires it. No child names.

MATERIALS LIST

ITEM	QUANTITY
H3 Pause-Check-Tell and Hackles-Up card	1 per family
H5 Say This, Not That card (adapted for families)	1 per family
Family Engagement Pack pages: Family Tech Agreement, Family Code Word guide, conversation starters, glossary, "What to do if your child tells you something scary"	1 set per family
Index cards and pens for questions and the code word	2 per person
Sample lesson cards (a few fake phish cards from H8 for the "Hackles Up or Down?" activity; use only D4, D9, D15 and D13)	1 deck
Feedback slips	1 per family
Sign-in sheet (first names only if policy requires)	1
Counselor card with how to reach them	many

05 The 30-minute agenda

CLOCK	MIN	SEGMENT	WHO
0:00-0:03	3	Welcome and the Hackles hook	Host
0:03-0:07	4	What is Hackles? What will your child learn?	Teacher voice
0:07-0:12	5	Activity 1: Hackles Up or Down?	Teacher voice
0:12-0:18	6	When your child tells you something hard	Counselor
0:18-0:23	5	Activity 2: Say it, and pick a code word	Counselor, helpers
0:23-0:27	4	Your questions	Host, counselor, teacher voice
0:27-0:30	3	Close: preview, opt-out, help, thank you	Host

Timing check. The segments add up to 30 minutes with no slack: 3 + 4 + 5 + 6 + 5 + 4 + 3. The spoken parts take about 11 minutes at a calm pace, and the rest is audience activity and transitions. To stay on time, start on the minute (don't wait for latecomers), keep introductions to one line each, and use the chime. **If you're running late:** in Activity 1 show only D4 and D9 (cut D15 and D13), and in Q&A take two questions and say "the counselor and I will stay for 15 minutes after, and we will answer every index card in the newsletter." Never cut the sentence, the code word, or the preview and opt-out information.

06 The script, minute by minute

0:00-0:03 WELCOME AND THE HACKLES HOOK (HOST)

SAY:

FIELD NOTE	No. 1
"Good evening, and thank you for coming. I know it takes effort to get here after a long day. I'm [name], the principal. Before anything else, I want to tell you what tonight is, and what it isn't. It is not a scary talk. I won't show you frightening statistics, and I won't tell you stories about children in trouble. Tonight is about skills: simple things you and your child can say and do, and the one sentence that matters most when a child comes to you with a problem." "Let me introduce the team. [Introduce the teacher voice and the counselor.] And one more thing up front. Our school does not collect any student accounts or student data in this program. Ever."	

Hackles hook (30 seconds):

FIELD NOTE	No. 2
"Has anyone here ever felt the hair on the back of your neck rise because something just felt off? (Show of hands.) That's what we call 'hackles.' Our program is named for that feeling, and we teach children to notice it and do something about it. Let me show you. (Do the Hackles Up signal: raise your hand and brush it up the back of your neck. Invite the room to try.) 'Hackles up' is only the first step. We'll practice the rest in a moment."	

0:03-0:07 WHAT IS HACKLES? WHAT WILL YOUR CHILD LEARN? (TEACHER VOICE)

SAY:

FIELD NOTE	No. 3
"Hackles is a free set of short lessons. Fifteen minutes each, mostly paper and pencil, and all of it practice. No lectures. Every lesson comes back to one routine. Hackles up? Pause. Check. Tell." "Hackles up means: notice that something feels off. Maybe it's too good to be true, or pushy, or secret, or scary. Pause means stop, take a breath, and don't click, reply, pay or send yet. Check means ask: who is it really? What do they want? How fast? And check a different way than the message tells you to. Tell means tell a trusted person, every time, with no shame. (Show the hand signals: flat palm for Pause, magnifying glass for Check, hand on chest then open palm for Tell. Invite the room to try.)" "Two promises we make to children in every lesson: a false alarm is fine and welcome, and if they missed it or got tricked, it is never their fault." "What do the lessons look like? In kindergarten through second grade, children practice saying 'I need help' and pressing a big paper Oops Button. In third to fifth, they sort real and fake messages and build passphrases. In middle school they work through fictional case files, and in high school they make their own digital defense plan. No child is ever asked to share a personal experience. We use characters and cards, never real children. For a few sensitive lessons we tell you in advance, and you can preview the lesson or choose an alternative. More on that at the end."	

0:07-0:12 ACTIVITY 1: HACKLES UP OR DOWN? (TEACHER VOICE)

SAY:

FIELD NOTE	No. 4
"Let's try one together. I'll hold up a card. If your hackles go up, make the Hackles Up signal. If it looks fine, give me a thumbs-up. There's no wrong answer. Ready?"	

Cards (fictional, from H8):

- D4 (pop-up):** "CONGRATULATIONS! You are visitor number 1,000,000! Claim 5,000 free GemCoins NOW! Type your username and password!" (Hackles Up.) Ask: "What made it feel off?" (Too good, wants a password, hurry.)
- D9 (grandma voicemail):** "A voice that sounds exactly like your grandmother: 'It's me. I'm in trouble. Please don't tell Mom. Send money to this number right now.'" (Hackles Up.) Say: "This one matters. Voices can be copied by computers now [VERIFY how common]. This is why we suggest a **Family Code Word**: a word only your family knows, so you can check. We'll make one in a few minutes."

3. **D15 (real text):** "Practice is cancelled today. Pick-up is at 3:15 at the usual door." (Hackles Down.) Say: "Calm is allowed. If every message made us panic, children would learn to ignore the signal."
4. **D13 (kids' pop-up):** "TAP HERE TO WIN A PUPPY! Don't tell your grown-up, it's a surprise!" (Hackles Up.) Say: "This is the version for our youngest. What's the clue? 'Don't tell your grown-up.' Secrets about a grown-up are always a Hackles Up."

SAY (closing the activity):

FIELD NOTE	No. 5
"Notice what we did: we noticed, we named the clue, and we agreed on the next move. That's the whole thing. You can do it at the kitchen table with a pop-up on a phone."	

0:12-0:18 WHEN YOUR CHILD TELLS YOU SOMETHING HARD (COUNSELOR)**SAY:**

FIELD NOTE	No. 6
"Thank you. I'm [name], the school counselor. I want to talk about the most important moment in a child's online life, which is the moment they decide whether to tell you something." "Most children are fine. Most use technology safely, most of the time. But sooner or later every child will click something they regret, see something that upsets them, or be treated unkindly. What decides how that goes isn't whether the problem happens. It's whether they tell someone. And the biggest reason children don't tell is shame. They're afraid they'll be blamed, punished, or have their phone taken away." "So here is the sentence that matters most. Say it with me. 'Thank you for telling me. This is not your fault. You are not in trouble.' (Room repeats.) Say it softly. Say it steadily. Say it first, before any question."	

SAY (the do's and don'ts, in a friendly voice, on the slide):

TO VERIFY

"Here's a quick cheat sheet. **Do:** thank them. Stay calm. Say 'This is not your fault.' Ask 'Tell me more' and 'What happened next?' Be honest: if it's serious, you may need to get help from other adults, and you'll tell them who. **Don't:** ask 'why did you do that?' Don't say 'you should have known better.' Don't threaten to take the phone, because fear of losing the device is a common reason kids stop telling. Don't promise to keep it a secret you can't keep. And if there are pictures involved, **don't look at them, forward them or screenshot them.** Keep the device safe and call us, or the right authority [VERIFY the numbers on your handout]."

"One last thing: you are not alone. If your child tells you something serious, you can call me. You don't have to figure it out by yourself. My number is on the card."

0:18-0:23 ACTIVITY 2: SAY IT, AND PICK A CODE WORD (COUNSELOR, HELPERS)

SAY:

FIELD NOTE

No. 7

"Let's practice. Turn to the person next to you. One of you is the parent and one of you is the child. The child says: 'I think I messed up. I clicked a link and my game account is doing weird things.' The parent says: 'Thank you for telling me. You're not in trouble. This happens to smart people. Tell me what happened.' Then swap. Thirty seconds each. Go."

(Walk around and listen. Smile. Praise.)

SAY (debrief, 30 seconds):

FIELD NOTE

No. 8

"How did that feel? (Take two comments.) That's the sentence we want in your mouth. You'll say it a hundred times over the years, nearly always about something small, and that's what makes it easy to say the one time it matters."

SAY (Family Code Word, 2 minutes):

FIELD NOTE

No. 9

"Now the code word. Take an index card. A Family Code Word is a silly word that only your family knows. If someone calls, or sends a voice message, and says 'it's me, I need help,' you ask: 'What's our code word?' If they can't say it, you hang up and call back on a number you already have. Pick a word that's easy to remember and hard to guess. Not a pet's name, not a street, not anything that's on social media. Write it on the card **at home**, not here, and keep it private. Here, just write the idea: 'Our code word will be a ___ word.' Tonight, decide with your family when you'll choose it."

0:23-0:27 YOUR QUESTIONS (HOST, COUNSELOR, TEACHER VOICE)

SAY:

FIELD NOTE

No. 10

"We have four minutes. Ask out loud, or write your question on an index card and hand it to me. If it's personal, please see [counselor] afterward or call [counselor]. There are no embarrassing questions."

Use the answers in Section 7. If time runs out, promise a written reply within a week: "We'll collect the cards and reply in the newsletter."

0:27-0:30 CLOSE: PREVIEW, OPT-OUT, HELP, THANK YOU (HOST)

SAY:

FIELD NOTE

No. 11

"Let me close with the practical parts. **You are welcome to preview any lesson.** [Say how: in person, by phone, on paper.] For a few lessons on sensitive topics, we will send you a letter two weeks before, and you can preview the lesson, ask questions or choose an alternative for your child. If you choose to opt out, we will respect that, and there is no penalty for your child. [Confirm your district's notice and opt-out rules with district counsel.] We'll make sure your child knows who to tell if anything ever worries them."

"Your take-home packet has the Family Tech Agreement, the Family Code Word guide, conversation starters and a one-page 'What to do if your child tells you something scary.' Try one thing this week. Just one."

"If you need help, call [counselor] at [number]. For emergencies, call 911. If you or someone in your family is in crisis, call or text 988. If you need to report a concern about online exploitation, NCMEC's CyberTipline is at report.cybertip.org. [VERIFY all numbers and links before you print or say them.]"

"Thank you for caring so much about our children. Let's finish the way our students do. Everybody: Hackles up? Pause. Check. Tell. (Signals.) Good night, and please fill in the feedback slip on your way out."

07 Questions families ask (and kind answers)

Try this now (2 minutes, before the night): read Q3, Q4 and Q9 aloud to a colleague and answer in your own words. Those three call for the most care.

Use these as a guide. Answer in your own voice. When you do not know, say "I don't know; let's find out," and write it down.

Q1. "Is this age-appropriate? Will it scare my child?"

A: "The lessons are age-banded, nothing is graphic, and nobody is asked to share a personal story. The youngest children practice saying 'I need help.' Older children practice with fictional characters. A counselor is on call for every sensitive lesson, and you can preview anything."

Q2. "Shouldn't this be taught at home?"

A: "Yes. And you're the most important teacher your child has. Our lessons are there to back up that conversation, because children do better when school and home say the same thing, which is why a card goes home with every lesson."

Q3. "What apps should I ban?"

A: "Apps change every year. What matters is the behavior: pressure, secrecy, a request to move to a private chat, or a request for pictures or money. If you see those, 'Hackles up' is the right response, no matter the app. Choosing which apps your child uses is your decision; the Family Tech Agreement is a tool for making rules together."

Q4. "Should I read my child's messages?"

A: "Families differ, and the right answer depends on your child's age and your family's values. Many experts encourage open conversation and agreed-upon rules [VERIFY with a current source]. Whatever you choose, tell your child, so it does not become a secret. The most protective thing is a child who knows they can tell you without being punished."

Q5. "What if my child's already clicked on something or been tricked?"

A: "It's okay. It happens to smart adults every day. Start with 'Thank you for telling me.' Then change the password, turn on two-step verification, and tell the platform if you need to. If money or pictures are involved, call us or the authorities. It is never your child's fault."

Q6. "What about AI chatbots and fake pictures?"

A: "Some AI tools can make convincing pictures, voices and videos. Most people cannot reliably tell by eye, so we teach children to **check the source**, not squint at pixels [VERIFY]. We also teach that AI chatbots can feel caring

but are not a person, can be wrong, and are not a substitute for a trusted adult."

Q7. "Will my child's information be collected?"

A: "No. Hackles has no student accounts, and we do not collect student data. The only data we collect is anonymous feedback from adults."

Q8. "Can I opt my child out?"

A: "For sensitive lessons, we will send a letter two weeks ahead with a preview option. If you opt out, we will offer a respectful alternative and make sure your child knows who to tell. No penalty. [Confirm local rules with district counsel.]"

Q9. "My child never tells me anything. How do I start?"

A: "Start small. Pick a conversation starter from the packet and use it in the car or while you're cooking, side by side and not face to face. Something like 'Did you ever see something online that felt weird? It happens to me all the time.' Thank them for any telling at all, even about something tiny."

Q10. "What if my child is the one who was mean?"

A: "Many children who are unkind online are struggling, and they can learn. Stay calm, talk about the harm done, help them repair it, and involve the counselor if you want support. We do not shame children."

Q11. "What if I do not speak English well or do not use technology?"

A: "You do not need to be a tech expert. You need to listen, stay calm and say the sentence. We have translated materials and interpreters. Ask any of us."

Q12. "What if my child has no phone at all?"

A: "Many children use friends' devices, school devices, game consoles and TVs. The routine works anywhere: Hackles up? Pause. Check. Tell."

Q13. "Why not 'don't talk to strangers'?"

A: "It is a start, but children also get tricked by people they half-know, by friends' hacked accounts and by messages that look friendly. We teach 'trusted adult' and 'check' so that the skill works in all of those situations."

Q14. "Who can I call if I'm worried?"

A: "Start with [counselor] at [number]. For emergencies, call 911. If someone is in crisis, call or text 988. For online exploitation, NCMEC's CyberTipline [VERIFIED 2026-10-05: hotline details checked on the organization's own site]."

08 If a parent shares something hard

A PARENT MAY SAY, during Q&A or afterward, "This happened to my child."
Be ready for it.

In the room (calmly, 15 seconds):

FIELD NOTE	No. 12
"Thank you for trusting us with that. I want to give it the attention it deserves, and not in front of the whole group. [Counselor] would like to talk with you right after, or I can bring you to a quiet room now."	

Then the counselor steps over, quietly. Do not ask for details in the room. Do not let other families ask.

Privately (counselor):

1. Thank them. "I'm so glad you told us."
2. Be honest about limits: "If a child may be in danger, we may need to report. I'll tell you who I tell." [VERIFY]
3. Listen. Do not probe.
4. Offer resources: the school counselor, the child's doctor, a local support organization, the helplines on the card. [VERIFY]
5. If the incident involves current harm to a child or involves images, follow the Disclosure and Incident Guide. Do not look at, ask for or accept images.
6. Offer follow-up within 24 hours.
7. Offer support to the parent, too: parents need care.

What not to do: do not promise secrecy; do not give legal advice; do not minimize ("that happens to everyone"); do not blame ("you should have..."); do not take photos or notes in front of the family without telling them.

If a parent is upset or angry about the program: listen. Say "I can hear that you care a lot. Thank you." Offer a preview and a private conversation. Do not argue in front of the group.

09 Slide cues (12 slides)

#	SLIDE	CONTENT	VISUAL
1	Welcome	"Hackles: helping our kids trust their gut online"	Logo; warm photo of students (with permission) or a drawing of Hackle
2	Tonight is...	Skills, not scares · Practical · Free · No student data	Three icons
3	Hackles up? Pause. Check. Tell.	The routine in four tiles	Hand signals
4	Two promises	A false alarm is fine. It is never your fault.	Large type, soft color
5	What kids learn	K-2 · 3-5 · 6-8 · 9-12 in one line each	Four small icons
6	Hackles Up or Down?	"On your signal"	Card image
7	Card examples	D4, D9, D15, D13	One card per click
8	The sentence	"Thank you for telling me. This is not your fault. You are not in trouble."	Giant type
9	Do and don't	Short two-column list	Green check, red X (gentle colors)
10	The Family Code Word	A word only your family knows	A silly drawing of a lock
11	You are not alone	Counselor name and number; 911; 988 [VERIFIED 2026-10-05: 988lifeline.org]	Phone icon
12	Thank you	Preview, opt-out, packet, feedback	Logo

Design: large type (28 pt or bigger), high contrast, no scary images, no hooded figures, no stock photos of "hackers."

10 Handouts for families

HANDOUT	SOURCE
Pause-Check-Tell and Hackles-Up card	H3
Say This, Not That (family version: the left column only, plus one line on secrecy)	H5
Family Tech Agreement	Family Engagement Pack
Family Code Word guide	Family Engagement Pack
Conversation starters	Family Engagement Pack
Glossary (decoder for words kids use: group chat, DM, screenshot, block and report, handle, AI chatbot, deepfake, two-step verification)	Family Engagement Pack; Teacher Primer
"What to do if your child tells you something scary" (one page)	Family Engagement Pack
Help list (counselor name and number, 911, 988, NCMEC CyberTipline, Take It Down) [VERIFIED 2026-10-05: takeitdown.ncmec.org]	H7
Preview and opt-out information	Counselor Toolkit

Translate every handout. Have a qualified translator or language-access team review translations; avoid unreviewed machine translation for sensitive topics. [VERIFY]

11 Virtual or hybrid version

- **Platform:** use a district-approved tool. [VERIFY policy] No child accounts. Families join with a link.
- **Chat:** allow questions in chat, moderated. Close chat to private messages.
- **Activity 1:** use thumbs-up and "raise a hand" reactions.
- **Activity 2:** use breakout rooms of two, with one adult from the school visiting each (or run it in the main room by asking pairs to talk quietly).
- **Counselor:** stays on after to take private questions.
- **No recording** unless your district and families approve in writing. [VERIFY]
- **Provide the packet** by email and print.

12 **Sample invitation, sign-in and feedback slip**

INVITATION

FIELD NOTE	No. 13
You're invited: Hackles Family Night Join us on [date] at [time] in [place] for a 30-minute, no-scare session on helping your child trust their gut online. Learn the Pause-Check-Tell routine your child will practice, try a quick activity, and take home free tools: a Family Code Word and conversation starters. Childcare, interpreters and snacks will be provided. RSVP to [contact] by [date]. Everyone is welcome. We do not collect any student data.	

SIGN-IN SHEET (FIRST NAMES OR INITIALS ONLY IF POLICY REQUIRES)

NAME	LANGUAGE I PREFER	I WOULD LIKE A CALL FROM THE COUNSELOR (Y OR N)

FEEDBACK SLIP (ANONYMOUS)

1. One thing I learned: _____
2. One thing I will try this week: _____
3. How welcome did you feel tonight? (1 not at all, 5 very): 1 2 3 4 5
4. A question I still have: _____
5. I would like to preview a lesson (circle): yes / no

Educational guidance, not legal advice. Consult your administrator and district counsel. [VERIFY]